

**Career Profiles In The Field Of Animation****3D Layout / Background Artist**

The layout / background artist must be an excellent cartoonist, capable of following the basic design of characters. He needs to research costumes, architecture, and landscapes. Sound knowledge of perspective and composition is essential.

**3D Character Animator**

Should have mastered the mechanics of animation (squash and stretch, overlapping, anticipation, timing, weight, body dynamics, secondary motions, etc.), and should have versatility in animating various styles of characters. Should be proficient in acting theory and practice. Fine draftsmanship is essential, as is the ability to make humorous drawings and actions. 2D key animation skills are essential.

**3D Modeller / Rigger**

Character Modellers: Should be able to model organic and complex forms. Must be proficient in polygon modelling, and should understand texturing and rigging requirements.

Sets Modellers / Props Modellers: Should understand texturing requirements, and should have a strong sense of proportion.

Rigging Artists: Should be able to design strong interactive rigs and simplify complex animation tasks. Should have good understanding of anatomy.

**3D Special Effects Artist**

Must possess a strong sense of dynamics. Should be able to visualise and render natural phenomena such as fire, water, smoke, cloth, etc. Should

have strong technical problem-solving skills, and know all the special effects tools and software.

**Lighting / Texturing Artist**

Must understand how to set scene mood and feel. Should be able to deliver photo-realistic frames. Must possess a minimum experience of one year.

**Compositor**

Should have knowledge of colour correction, masking, tracking and wire removal. Proficiency in online editing software is required.

**Programmer**

Should have Knowledge of MEL scripting, C, C++, VB, Perl Scripting, the RenderMan Shading Language, XSI and Maya.

Mr. Pai advises aspirants to the field, “One would like to dispel the common misconception that getting into the animation or gaming industry requires one to learn or gain expertise in the latest versions of imaging software. The fact is, the various software are just tools. Anyone can learn to use these tools. The essence is to have the inherent creative talent to be able to use those tools to create works of art. That is what students should concentrate on.

“Technology professionals should also widen their horizons and look at the wonderful opportunities that this industry provides, rather than following the herd into staid careers in programming with software giants. As the industry grows, their careers will grow proportionately.”

Rajesh Turakhia, CEO of Mumbai-based Maya Entertainment Ltd (MEL), which also has a training division, the Maya Academy Of Advanced Cinematics (MAAC), says, “Out-sourcing projects for TV and film typically extend over a period of two to three years. During this period new projects keep coming in, which require more manpower. According to Turakhia, when 2D ruled the roost it was Korea, China and the Philippines which were locations of choice. “But India, though a late entrant, has managed to gain ground in 3D. Also, we appreciate the American sense of humour and timing better,” adds Turakhia.

**Institutes**

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|-----------------------|----------------------|
| 1NID, Ahmedabad       | 1National Multimedia |
| 1Aptech-Arena         | Resource Centre -    |
| 1Zee Institute Of     | CDAC Pune            |
| Creative Arts: 3-year | 1Toonz Animation     |
| diploma in Animation  | Academy, Trivandrum  |
| 1Industrial Design    | 1Toonz Webel         |
| Centre (IIT Mumbai,   | Animation Academy,   |
| IIT Guwahati)         | Kolkata              |

“3D is where the action is, and aspirants should consider this avenue. Growth is only limited by one’s creativity. From a starting salary of Rs 8,000 per month for a trainee, three years can see one taking home Rs 75,000 per month as a Team Lead,” informs Turakhia.

Turakhia’s advice to young aspirants: “Animation, the universal language, can form the skill set for a serious career. Apart from entertainment, opportunities exist in sectors such as education and architecture. Considering the potential of the industry, a well-thought-out decision should be taken by parents and youngsters.”

Micheal Laxman, member of the technical team at MAAC says, “This is the field for those who are fascinated with visual effects.” Though proficiency in drawing or sketching is a welcome pre-requisite for the one-year course the academy runs, they have a month’s foundation course for those lacking the basics. The Maya course covers areas of 3D animation, visual effects and editing for film and TV.

According to Laxman, of the 300-odd students who pass out of the institute, 12 have been placed with MEL. Towards the end of the year, this figure is set to go up to 100.

**Hotting Up**

The animation industry is getting ready for more projects and revenues. Avenues for the display of talent are coming up. 24FPS—an animation film festival organized by MAAC—is scheduled for April, and invites entries from across the country. In a creative field, the need for recognition is high, and these are avenues for hidden talents to make themselves known.

The message seems to be to look beyond the glamour and fancy salaries and take a leap into the field only when one is convinced about talent and the ability to use the medium to communicate. ■

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